



1888, decided to move the competition to Kolkata, the nerve centre of Indian football.

The move sparked a revival, with almost all the leading teams in the country confirming their participation and restoring some of the tournament's lost prestige.

The All India Football Federation (AIFF) also welcomed the opportunity, making the Durand Cup the season opener. For the clubs, it became a useful tournament to assess their preparedness and squad composition ahead of a long league calendar. But Indian football has since entered a period of uncertainty following the departure of Football Sports Development Limited, the commercial partner and promoter of the ISL.

The football calendar has become increasingly topsy-turvy. The Durand Cup, however, seems to have bucked that trend.

The 24-team tournament is played over a month across five cities in eastern and northeastern India, with group and knockout stages. Ranchi was added as a new venue this year, replacing Jamshedpur.

Kolkata remains the quintessential Durand Cup arena, drawing enormous interest, but the passion has spread to Shillong, Imphal and Guwahati as well. The enthusiasm was particularly striking in Manipur, where football offered a welcome sense of togetherness amid continuing political turmoil.

"The stadium was sold out. The cheering, accompanied by Mexican waves, continued throughout the game. There was genuine support for football. There were around 5,000 to 6,000 people waiting outside to get in," said Major General Dinesh Kumar Singh, vice-chairman of the Durand Cup Organising Committee (DCOC).

"Despite the problems in the region, sport - and football in particular - has been a binding factor. So, in whatever small way sport can bring happiness and bring society together, it certainly helps. We intend to continue with this in future editions as well," he added.

Beyond the big-city crowds, the tournament also provided a stage for emerging clubs. Manipur's FC Raengdai was one of its biggest revelations, producing an impressive run to the quarterfinals before losing to ISL side Sporting Club Delhi.

Shillong Lajong FC once again showcased Meghalaya's footballing prowess. It established a 2-1 half-time lead over defending champion NorthEast United FC, which fought back in the second half, riding on a hat-trick by Moroccan striker Alaaeddine Ajaraie.

Six out of 14 ISL teams (including the now-relegated Mohammedan Sporting) participated alongside clubs from the second tier of Indian football, the Armed Forces and CISF Protectors.

"If all the ISL teams participate, then what is the difference between

Victory, at last: Two decades of frustration gave way to a night of unrestrained joy as East Bengal ended its Durand Cup title drought.

the ISL and the Durand Cup?" Maj. Gen. Singh said. "We therefore want a healthy mix of ISL teams, other football league teams and local clubs."

That approach also gave several new clubs from Assam, Meghalaya and Manipur the chance to test themselves against some of the country's best sides and players, including foreign recruits.

The quarterfinals featured five ISL teams: East Bengal, Bagan, NorthEast United, Sporting Club Delhi and Jamshedpur FC. Four of them progressed to the semifinals. Both last-four games were decided through tie-breakers, setting up another Kolkata Derby for the title.

The tournament had opened with the same fixture on July 25, when Bagan won 1-0 through Sahal Abdul Samad's second-half goal. In the final, however, East Bengal redeemed itself. Edmund Lalrindika was the star of the evening, scoring a precious hat-trick as East Bengal swept aside its oldest rival with a show of dominance. The performance brought an end to the club's 22-year wait for the Durand Cup and added another unforgettable chapter to Indian football's oldest and fiercest rivalry.